

TOURNAMENT RULEBOOK

Official Format & Competition Guidelines — v4.0

TOURNAMENT RULEBOOK

Official Format & Competition Guidelines — v4.0

SECTION 0: TOURNAMENT AT A GLANCE

This section gives a complete bird's-eye view of the tournament before the detailed rules of each section are explained. Read this first, then refer to the relevant section for full rules.

0.1 The Three Categories

Category	Discipline	Eligibility	Max Pairs	Groups
C1 — Advanced* Doubles	Men's Doubles / Mixed Doubles	Internal players only	16 pairs	A, B, C, D
C2 — Intermediate* Doubles	Men's Doubles / Mixed Doubles	Internal players only	20 pairs	E, F, G, H
C3 — Women's Doubles	Women's Doubles	Internal + External / Internal + Internal / External + External	20 pairs	I, J, K, L

* **Advanced and Intermediate:** These categories represent a player's overall standard within GZD Badminton Club for tournament purposes. They are determined primarily based on **eBadders records** and, where these are insufficient or do not accurately reflect a player's standard, on the organisers' assessment of the player's performances within the club. They are not a general assessment of a player's badminton ability.

Note: If a mixed doubles is playing against a men's doubles, a **4-point advantage** will be applied to the mixed doubles at the start of all games.

0.2 The Big Picture

Every category follows the same two-stage structure, run across a single day:

- **Stage 1** — Group Stage: 4 groups per category (Cat 1: 4 pairs/group, Cat 2/Cat 3: 5 pairs/group), round robin within each group. Top 2 per group qualify.
- **Stage 2** — Knockout Stage: 8 qualifying pairs per category play Quarterfinals → Semifinals → Bronze Match + Final.

The tournament is a one-day event running from 9:30am to approximately 5:45pm. Cat 1 and Cat 2 group stages run in parallel first, followed by Cat 3's group stage, then a coordinated knockout stage for all three categories sharing the same courts.

0.3 Format Summary

Stage	Pairs	Format	Deciding Factor
Group Stage	C1: 16 (4 groups of 4) C2/C3: 20 max each (4 groups of 5)	Round robin, 21 pts, 1 set, no deuce	Match wins, then point difference
Quarterfinals	8 per category	Best of 3 sets, 21 pts, no deuce	Match wins
Semifinals	4 per category	Best of 3 sets, 21 pts, no deuce	Match wins
Bronze Match	2 per category	Best of 3 sets, 21 pts, no deuce	Match wins
Final	2 per category	Best of 3 sets, 21 pts, deuce (cap 30)	Match wins

Note: If a mixed doubles is playing against a men's doubles, a 4-point advantage will be applied to the mixed doubles at the start of all games.

SECTION 1: CATEGORIES & ELIGIBILITY

The tournament runs three parallel categories, each with its own groups, knockout bracket, and eligibility rules.

1.1 Category 1 — Advanced Doubles

- Open to Men's Doubles (MD) and Mixed Doubles (XD) pairs at an advanced skill level **within GZD**.
- Internal players only — both players in a pair must be internal players.
- Maximum 16 pairs, divided into 4 groups (A, B, C, D) of 4 pairs each.

1.2 Category 2 — Intermediate Doubles

- Open to Men's Doubles (MD) and Mixed Doubles (XD) pairs at an intermediate skill level **within GZD**.
- Internal players only — both players in a pair must be internal players.
- Maximum 20 pairs, divided into 4 groups (E, F, G, H) of 5 pairs each.

1.3 Category 3 — Women's Doubles

- Women's Doubles (WD) pairs only.
- Open to both internal and external players. A pair may freely mix from both internal and/or external player.
- Maximum 20 pairs, divided into 4 groups (I, J, K, L) of 5 pairs each.

1.4 Categorisation, Pairing & Grouping

- For **Cat 1 & 2**, players should register **individually**, and categorisation and pairing will be determined after the registration of all players according to eBadders records or a player's overall performance in GZD.
- Categorisation will be determined on 28 August 2026 (Friday) at 7pm.
- **Cat 1 & 2** pairing will be determined by a draw, on 29 August 2026 (Saturday) at 12pm.
- For **Cat 3 Women's Doubles**, both internal and external players will be required to register **in pairs**. Any one of the players can register their pair.
- Grouping for **Cat 3** will be determined after the registration of all players according to sign-up form response.

1.5 Pair Withdrawal Policy

If a registered pair withdraws before or during the group stage, their remaining group matches are recorded as byes for their scheduled opponents. Group standings are calculated based on matches actually played; the withdrawn pair is removed from ranking calculations.

Note: If a mixed doubles is playing against a men's doubles, a 4-point advantage will be applied to the mixed doubles at the start of all games.

SECTION 2: GROUP STAGE

The Group Stage is the opening stage for every category. Within each group, every pair plays every other pair in their group exactly once. The top 2 pairs from each group advance to the Knockout Stage.

2.1 Group Stage at a Glance

Category	Groups	Pairs/Group	Matches/Group	Games/Pair	Total Matches
C1	A, B, C, D	4	6	3	24
C2	E, F, G, H	5	10	4	40
C3	I, J, K, L	5	10	4	40

C1's groups of 4 pairs produce 6 matches each (**every pair plays 3 games**). C2 and C3's groups of 5 pairs produce 10 matches each (**every pair plays 4 games**).

2.2 Match Format

Each group stage match is a single set, first to 21 points, no deuce - a straight race to 21. The first pair to reach 21 points wins the match outright.

2.3 Group Stage Qualification & Ranking

At the end of the group stage, the top 2 pairs from each group advance to the Knockout Stage. Rankings within each group are determined by the following criteria, applied in order until the tie is broken:

- 1. **Match wins** — the pair with more match wins ranks higher.
- 2. **Point difference** — if pairs are tied on match wins, the pair with the higher combined point difference across all group matches ranks higher.
- 3. **Head-to-head** — if still tied, results are compared only among the tied pairs (re-applying match wins, then point difference, within that smaller group).
- 4. **Draw of lots** — if the tie persists after all of the above, a draw of lots decides the final ranking.

2.4 Group Stage Timing

Component	C1	C2 / C3
Each match (21 pts, 1 set, no deuce)	~12 minutes (10 play + 2 organising)	~12 minutes (10 play + 2 organising)
Matches per group	6	10
Time per group (one dedicated court)	~72 minutes (1h 12m)	~120 minutes (2 hours)

Because C1 has fewer pairs per group, its group stage finishes well ahead of C2 and C3. C1's courts sit free from that point until the shared Knockout Wave 1 begins, giving the day extra buffer rather than being reallocated mid-round-robin.

SECTION 3: KNOCKOUT STAGE

The Knockout Stage brings together the top 2 pairs from each of the 4 groups within a category — 8 pairs in total. Each category runs its own independent bracket: 4 Quarterfinals, 2 Semifinals, 1 Bronze Match, and 1 Final.

3.1 Knockout Stage at a Glance

- 8 qualifying pairs per category (2 from each of 4 groups)
- Quarterfinals: 4 matches, cross-group pairing
- Semifinals: 2 matches, fixed bracket from QF winners
- Bronze Match: SF losers play for third place
- Final: SF winners play for first place

3.2 Quarterfinal Bracket

Quarterfinal pairings cross-pair each group's winner against the neighbouring group's runner-up, so that two pairs from the same group cannot meet again until the Semifinals at the earliest:

Match	Pairing
QF1	Group 1 Winner vs Group 2 Runner-Up
QF2	Group 2 Winner vs Group 1 Runner-Up
QF3	Group 3 Winner vs Group 4 Runner-Up
QF4	Group 4 Winner vs Group 3 Runner-Up

For C1, "Group 1–4" refers to Groups A–D respectively; for C2, Groups E–H; for C3, Groups I–L.

3.3 Semifinal Bracket

Match	Pairing
SF1	QF1 Winner vs QF2 Winner
SF2	QF3 Winner vs QF4 Winner

SF1 and SF2 winners advance to the Final. SF1 and SF2 losers play the Bronze Match.

3.4 Match Format

Round	Format	Deuce	Est. Max Duration
Quarterfinal	Best of 3 sets, 21 pts	No deuce (hard cap at 21)	~45 minutes
Semifinal	Best of 3 sets, 21 pts	No deuce (hard cap at 21)	~45 minutes
Bronze Match	Best of 3 sets, 21 pts	No deuce (hard cap at 21)	~45 minutes
Final	Best of 3 sets, 21 pts	Deuce, capped at 30	~60 minutes

Each knockout set is estimated at approximately 15 minutes. A best-of-3 match therefore runs 30–45 minutes for non-deuce rounds. The Final's deuce rule allows play to continue past 21 points if the score reaches 20-20, with the first pair to lead by 2 points — or reach 30 points, whichever comes first — winning the set.

3.5 Walkover Policy

If a pair retires or withdraws from a knockout match, their opponent receives an automatic walkover into the next round. For example, if a Semi-finalist withdraws, their opponent advances directly to the Final, and the Bronze Match is contested by the two Semifinal losers as normal (or reassigned per Tournament Director discretion if a withdrawal affects the Bronze pairing).

SECTION 4: COURTS & SCHEDULE

This section lays out how courts are allocated across the day and the full minute-by-minute schedule.

4.1 Court Availability

- 8 courts available from 9:30am to 3:00pm (Hall C + D)
- 4 courts available from 3:00pm to 6:00pm (Hall C)
- Tournament begins at 9:30am sharp — no separate briefing buffer

4.2 Court Allocation Principles

- Courts are allocated in dedicated blocks per category rather than a shared open pool.
- Dynamic reallocation applies: if a category finishes its current phase early, its freed courts are reassigned to help other categories finish faster.
- Group stage matches run on one dedicated court per group where possible, so that a group's full round robin plays out sequentially on the same court.

4.3 Full Day Schedule

Time	Courts	Phase	Matches
9:30–10:42am	4	Group Stage A (C1)	C1 group stage completes early (~72 min); courts idle as buffer until Wave 1
9:30–11:30am	4	Group Stage A (C2)	C2 group stage (~120 min, sets the pace for Phase A)
11:30am–12:30pm	8 (2/group)	Group Stage B	C3 group stage
12:30–1:15pm	8 (4+4)	Knockout Wave 1	C1 QF ×4, C2 QF ×4
1:15–2:00pm	8 (2+2+4)	Knockout Wave 2	C1 SF ×2, C2 SF ×2, C3 QF ×4
2:00–2:45pm	4	Knockout Wave 3	C3 SF ×2, C1 Bronze, C2 Bronze
2:45pm–3:00pm	—	Buffer	Absorbs any upstream schedule slippage
2:45–3:45pm*	2	Knockout Wave 4a	C3 Final + C3 Bronze
3:45–4:45pm	1	Knockout Wave 4b	C2 Final
4:45–5:45pm	1	Knockout Wave 4c	C1 Final

**Wave 4a begins at 2:45pm if the schedule is on time; the dedicated 2:45–3:00pm slot exists specifically to absorb any delay accumulated earlier in the day.*

Estimated finish: approximately 5:45pm, giving roughly 15 minutes of buffer before the 6:00pm venue cutoff under worst-case (maximum duration) assumptions. Matches typically finish faster than the maximum estimate, so in practice more buffer is expected.

4.4 Timing Assumptions

- **Group stage matches:** ~10 minutes play + ~2 minutes organising (~12 min/match) — group matches to 21 points typically finish comfortably under the cap.
- **Knockout matches:** ~15 minutes per set (more conservative estimate, reflecting the higher stakes and longer rallies of elimination matches).
- **Between-match rest:** pairs playing back-to-back matches (e.g. a Quarterfinal immediately followed by a Semifinal) receive 2–3 minutes of rest between matches.

4.5 Officiating & Player Welfare

- 20 umpires rotate across the day's courts; capacity has been confirmed sufficient to cover simultaneous match waves, including the 8-court peaks.
- There is no dedicated lunch break in the schedule. Umpires rotate and manage meals informally; players are responsible for their own meal timing around their match schedule.
- On the day of the event, Great British Doner, an official partner of GZD Badminton Club, will provide catering at the event, with 10% off all food purchases. Details of the price list is provided below.
- **GZD will also provide light snacks and drinks for all participants.**



*Great British Doner menu above. Catering will be available from 11:00 am onwards on 12 September 2026. Catering end time is subject to availability of supplies.

SECTION 5: QUICK REFERENCE

5.1 Scoring at a Glance

Stage	Points	Sets	Deuce
Group Stage (all categories)	21	1	No deuce — straight race
Quarterfinal / Semifinal / Bronze	21	Best of 3	No deuce — hard cap at 21
Final	21	Best of 3	Deuce — win by 2, capped at 30

Note: If a mixed doubles is playing against a men's doubles, a 4-point advantage will be applied to the mixed doubles at the start of all games.

5.2 Category Snapshot

Rule	C1	C2	C3
Discipline	MD + XD	MD + XD	WD only
Level	Advanced	Intermediate	Open
Eligibility	Internal only	Internal only	Internal + External
Max Pairs	16	20	20
Groups	A, B, C, D	E, F, G, H	I, J, K, L

SECTION 6: TOURNAMENT OFFICIALS

6.1 Tournament Director

Oversees the tournament, including implementation of the tournament format, schedule, and enforcement of the rules. Decisions made by the Tournament Director on tournament matters are final.

6.2 Technical Advisors

The Tournament Organiser appoints Technical Advisors (non-participants) to provide guidance on matters relating to the tournament system, regulations, and tournament procedures. From time to time, feedback may be sought or received from participants. Any such feedback shall be regarded as informal discussion only and shall not constitute formal or confer any decision-making authority.

6.3 Head Referee

Overall authority over officiating matters during the tournament. Head referee ensures that matches are conducted according to the rules and may take rulings on disputes or rule interpretations during play.

6.4 Lead Umpires

Supervises the umpiring team during matches and coordinates the work of the other umpires. The lead umpires ensure that all umpires perform their duties consistently and in accordance with the tournament rules.

6.5 Umpires

A pool of 20 rotating umpires officiates matches, enforces the rules during play, and reports any issues to the Lead Umpires or Head Referee when necessary. Participants will not be assigned to officiate matches involving their own category or team.

- End of Rulebook -